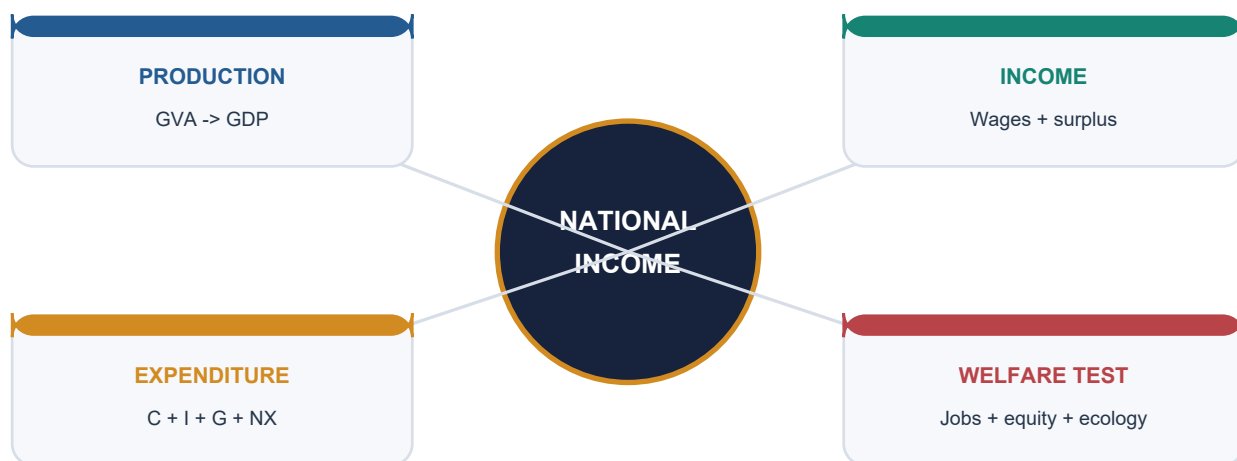


The Harappan Civilization

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Deterministic fallback visual: national income viewed through production, income, expenditure and welfare lenses.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

The Harappan Civilization - Learner-v2 Complete Learning Session	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
Audited MCQ Set: 40 Total Questions = 32 Core + 8 Remedial - [CORE PRELIMS]	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	11
Verification and answer protocol - [CORE MAINS]	12
Verified Question 1 - 2019 Prelims GS-I Q7: Non-Harappan Site	12
Verified Question 2 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q32: Ancient Water Harvesting	12
Verified Question 3 - 2025 Prelims GS-I Q72: Dancing Girl Material	12
Verified Question 4 - 2026 Prelims GS-I Q8: Household Artefacts and Inference	12
Verified Question 5 - 2025 GS-I Q1: Salient Features of Harappan Architecture	12
Original Mains 1 - 10 marks: Civic Urbanism	12
Original Mains 2 - 10 marks: Label Caution	13
Original Mains 3 - 15 marks: Urban-Rural System and Economy	13
Original Mains 4 - 15 marks: Script, Ritual and Social Inference	13
Original Mains 5 - 20 marks: Decline as Transformation	13
Original Mains 6 - 20 marks: Standardisation and Authority	14

The Harappan Civilization - Learner-v2 Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Audited MCQ Set: 40 Total Questions = 32 Core + 8 Remedial - [CORE PRELIMS]

Every question below has topic-specific options, a fixed A -> B -> C -> D answer rotation and a close-distractor explanation. Core questions are 1-32; remedial questions are 33-40.

MCQ 1

With reference to Harappan chronology, consider the following statements:

1. The Mature Harappan phase is conventionally placed c. 2600-1900 BCE.
2. The Early Harappan phase represents regional and proto-urban development.
3. The Late Harappan phase is best treated as an interval without settlement continuity.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A. Statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.

MCQ 2

Which one of the following pairs is correctly matched?

- A. Harappa - Great Bath
- B. Dholavira - reservoirs and a distinctive tripartite plan
- C. Kalibangan - Dancing Girl figurine
- D. Lothal - giant signboard

Answer: B. Dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.

MCQ 3

Consider the following site-feature pairs:

1. Mohenjo-daro - Great Bath
2. Kalibangan - ploughed-field evidence
3. Chanhudaro - specialised craft production

How many of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

- A. Only one
- B. Only two
- C. All three
- D. None

Answer: C. All three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.

MCQ 4

Which one of the following is the most appropriate inference from shared brick conventions, weights and seals across many Mature Harappan settlements?

- A. They prove a deciphered imperial law code.
- B. They prove every settlement had the same layout.
- C. They prove the presence of coinage.
- D. They indicate wide shared norms and coordination, while the exact political mechanism remains debated.

Answer: D. Material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.

MCQ 5

The Great Bath is especially useful in a Harappan architecture answer because it provides evidence for

- A. water-related public or collective built form at Mohenjo-daro
- B. a securely identified royal palace at Harappa
- C. a translated ritual doctrine
- D. a universal three-part town plan

Answer: A. Its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.

MCQ 6

Why is Dholavira particularly important for correcting a simplistic account of Harappan town planning?

- A. It alone has evidence of any water management.
- B. Its tripartite plan and reservoirs show regional variation within broader urban coordination.
- C. It proves that all Harappan settlements were coastal ports.
- D. It contains the Great Bath.

Answer: B. Dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.

MCQ 7

Consider the following statements about Harappan drainage:

1. Household drains, wells and street drains are material evidence for planned built practice.
2. Their presence directly identifies the title of the authority that maintained them.
3. Their layout can support an inference of recurring civic maintenance.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.

MCQ 8

With reference to functional labels in Harappan archaeology, which one of the following is correct?

- A. 'Citadel' is a Harappan word preserved in inscriptions.
- B. The basin at Lothal has been conclusively translated as a harbour.

C. 'Granary' establishes that a building stored state tax in grain.

D. Terms such as 'dockyard' and 'granary' are conventional interpretations that must be tested against context.

Answer: D. These are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.

MCQ 9

Which one of the following combinations best represents a Harappan economic foundation?

A. agriculture and pastoral resources linked to specialised craft and exchange

B. iron smelting linked to punch-marked coinage

C. temple estates linked to deciphered tax records

D. only long-distance trade, with no local production

Answer: A. Urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.

MCQ 10

Which one of the following is correctly associated with Harappan textile production?

A. Iron sickles and silk looms

B. spindle whorls, textile impressions and cotton production

C. Roman amphorae and glass blowing

D. punch-marked coins and guild seals

Answer: B. Spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.

MCQ 11

Consider the following statements:

1. Standard weights and scales support the inference of regular measurement in exchange.
2. Their use proves that Harappans used minted coinage.
3. Weights can be discussed with seals and craft production as parts of an integrated economy.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

A. 1 only

B. 2 and 3 only

C. 1 and 3 only

D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.

MCQ 12

Mesopotamian references to Meluhha, Dilmun and Magan are most useful for establishing

A. that Harappan script has been deciphered in Mesopotamia

B. that Dilmun was a Harappan capital

C. that all Harappan trade was controlled by one king

D. long-distance exchange links, while exact routes, volumes and control remain qualified

Answer: D. The terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.

MCQ 13

In Mesopotamian textual references, Meluhha is conventionally connected in UPSC preparation with

- A. the Indus/Harappan world or a wider eastern zone
- B. the Vedic kingdom of Kuru
- C. a Harappan name for Dholavira alone
- D. a Roman port on the Red Sea

Answer: A. Meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.

MCQ 14

Which one of the following statements about Harappan script is most accurate?

- A. It has yielded a continuous historical chronicle.
- B. It is undeciphered; short inscriptions and seal context can be analysed without claiming a translation.
- C. It is conclusively Brahmi written only left to right.
- D. It provides king-lists comparable to Mesopotamia.

Answer: B. The script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.

MCQ 15

Seals and sealings are most cautiously used by historians to discuss

- A. a complete Harappan epic tradition
- B. the personal beliefs of every household
- C. administrative, ownership-related or transactional practices inferred from context
- D. a securely known caste code

Answer: C. Seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.

MCQ 16

Which one of the following is the safest statement regarding Harappan religious interpretation?

- A. Female figurines conclusively prove one Mother Goddess cult.
- B. The horned seal figure is securely identified as Shiva.
- C. Fire installations prove a uniform state religion.
- D. Figurines, motifs and installations indicate possible ritual practices, but names and doctrines remain unsettled.

Answer: D. Material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.

MCQ 17

The absence of unambiguous palaces, royal tombs and monumental temples is most relevant to which conclusion?

- A. the exact form of Harappan polity and state religion remains debated
- B. Harappans had no organised civic life
- C. Harappans did not build substantial structures
- D. all settlements were politically independent villages

Answer: A. Absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.

MCQ 18

Which one of the following best reflects the range of Harappan polity models?

- A. A known hereditary monarchy only
- B. centralised state, city-states, or decentralised/corporate elite networks

- C. a modern parliamentary federation
- D. no social coordination of any kind

Answer: B. The material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.

MCQ 19

Consider the following statements about social inference:

1. Variation in house size may suggest unequal access to resources.
2. House size alone proves a fixed caste system.
3. Burial and household evidence require context and comparison before social conclusions are drawn.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C. Variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.

MCQ 20

Which one of the following is least compatible with the current explanation of Harappan decline?

- A. regional variation in change after c. 1900 BCE
- B. interaction of environmental, exchange and internal factors
- C. Late Harappan continuities in changed settings
- D. a single universally proven invasion event that explains every region

Answer: D. The last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.

MCQ 21

The phrase 'de-urbanisation with continuity' is preferred because it

- A. recognises changed urban traits while retaining Late Harappan communities and practices
- B. denies that any urban features changed
- C. means every city remained unchanged after 1900 BCE
- D. treats chronology as irrelevant

Answer: A. It captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.

MCQ 22

Which one of the following is a defensible use of river/environmental evidence in explaining Harappan change?

- A. A river shift conclusively explains every Harappan settlement.
- B. It may be a contributing factor whose relevance must be bounded by region, chronology and other evidence.
- C. It proves the identity of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati.
- D. It makes trade and internal change irrelevant.

Answer: B. Environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.

MCQ 23

Consider the following statements regarding Late Harappan developments:

1. Urban traits weakened unevenly after c. 1900 BCE.
2. Regional material traditions became more prominent.
3. Agricultural diversification and settlement shifts are relevant to the phase.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

Answer: C. All three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.

MCQ 24

Which one of the following site-location statements is correct?

- A. Harappa lies on the Indus in Sindh.
- B. Mohenjo-daro lies in the Rann of Kutch.
- C. Kalibangan is a coastal site in Gujarat.
- D. Rakhigarhi is in Haryana and Dholavira is in Kutch, Gujarat.

Answer: D. Rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.

MCQ 25

Which one of the following correctly describes the Harappan civilisation?

- A. a Bronze Age urban culture with wide regional extent beyond the Indus valley
- B. an Iron Age culture limited to the middle Ganga plain
- C. a literate culture whose script is fully deciphered
- D. a civilisation documented mainly by royal chronicles

Answer: A. It is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.

MCQ 26

The Mohenjo-daro Dancing Girl is most directly used in UPSC preparation to identify

- A. iron casting
- B. bronze casting and material culture
- C. a Vedic sacrificial ritual
- D. a royal portrait with known inscription

Answer: B. The figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.

MCQ 27

Which one of the following sets contains only Harappan evidence commonly used for specialised production or measurement?

- A. ploughed field, horse stirrup, iron ploughshare
- B. Brahmi inscription, punch-marked coin, glass bead
- C. bead workshops, spindle whorls, standard weights/scales
- D. Ashokan pillar, seal of a guild, Roman amphora

Answer: C. Bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.

MCQ 28

A candidate writes: 'The Harappan citadel proves a centralised monarchy.' Which revision is most evidence-sensitive?

- A. Replace 'citadel' with 'temple' and retain the conclusion.
- B. Add that all cities had identical citadels.
- C. Use the Dancing Girl as proof of monarchy.
- D. State that raised/planned sectors and standardisation indicate coordination, while the form of authority remains debated.

Answer: D. The revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.

MCQ 29

Which one of the following claims rests on the strongest category of Harappan evidence?

- A. covered drains and wells indicate developed water-related built practice
- B. the horned seal identifies a named deity
- C. a figurine proves universal female religious authority
- D. a large building proves its use as a state granary

Answer: A. Construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.

MCQ 30

For a 150-word answer on Harappan architecture, which sequence is most effective?

- A. religious labels -> a list of every site -> conclusion
- B. planned layout and building technology -> water/drainage -> named regional example -> functional-label caution
- C. modern conservation news -> dynasty list -> trade route
- D. one claim about an emperor -> an unqualified verdict

Answer: B. The second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.

MCQ 31

Consider the following statements:

1. Lothal is useful for bead-working and a basin conventionally identified as a dockyard.
2. Dholavira is useful for reservoirs and a large signboard.
3. Kalibangan is useful for a ploughed-field association.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 2 and 3 only

Answer: C. All three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is interpretive.

MCQ 32

Which one of the following statements best distinguishes an observation from an inference?

- A. 'The Harappans used drainage' is an inference, whereas 'they had an emperor' is observation.

- B. 'The script is translated' is observation, whereas a seal is an inference.
- C. 'Mother Goddess' is a material observation, whereas a figurine is speculation.
- D. 'A seal carries a horned figure' is observation; identifying it as Pashupati is an interpretation.

Answer: D. The image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.

Remedial MCQ 33

Which one of the following is correct about Harappan metallurgy?

- A. It was primarily Bronze Age technology; iron is not a characteristic Harappan metal.
- B. It was based on iron and steel comparable to the Mauryan period.
- C. It is known only through gold coinage.
- D. It is inferred solely from Vedic texts.

Answer: A. Harappan metalwork is a Bronze Age association, including copper-tin alloys. Iron, coinage and Vedic-only evidence misplace its technology and sources.

Remedial MCQ 34

Which one of the following pairs is incorrectly matched?

- A. Mohenjo-daro - Great Bath
- B. Dholavira - ploughed field
- C. Kalibangan - ploughed field
- D. Harappa - Ravi

Answer: B. The ploughed-field association is Kalibangan's, not Dholavira's. Dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor.

Remedial MCQ 35

Consider the following statements:

1. The horse was not a characteristic Harappan animal.
2. Reported horse remains, such as at Surkotada, are debated.
3. Therefore horse evidence establishes a horse-centred Harappan economy.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C. The first two are the cautious position. A debated and limited association cannot establish a characteristic horse-centred economy.

Remedial MCQ 36

Why should an aspirant write 'basin conventionally identified as a dockyard' for Lothal?

- A. Because no basin was excavated at Lothal.
- B. Because all Harappan structures were religious monuments.
- C. Because the phrase proves that Harappans had no maritime links.
- D. Because the structure is real but its exact function is an archaeological interpretation rather than a readable self-label.

Answer: D. This wording preserves the substantial structure and its exchange relevance while honestly marking the limit on functional certainty.

Remedial MCQ 37

Which sequence correctly orders the broad Harappan process?

- A. Early regional/proto-urban development -> Mature integration/urbanism -> Late localisation and changed settlement
- B. Mature integration -> Early regional development -> Iron Age urbanism
- C. Late urbanisation -> Mature pastoral nomadism -> Early coinage
- D. Vedic monarchy -> Harappan towns -> Mauryan drainage

Answer: A. The first sequence matches the standard Early-Mature-Late process framework. The other choices reverse phases or introduce unrelated later formations.

Remedial MCQ 38

Which one of the following statements about Harappan exchange is correct?

- A. Punch-marked coins were the standard medium of Harappan trade.
- B. Standard weights, seals, commodities and exchange networks are better-supported than coinage.
- C. Meluhha was the name of a deciphered Harappan currency.
- D. Trade evidence proves that all craft production was imported.

Answer: B. Weights/seals and material networks support regulated transactions without coinage. Meluhha is a Mesopotamian exchange term, not a translated currency.

Remedial MCQ 39

The verified 2025 Prelims question on the Mohenjo-daro Dancing Girl principally tests the association of the figurine with

- A. a dockyard at Lothal
- B. a ploughed field at Kalibangan
- C. bronze
- D. an undeciphered script at Dholavira

Answer: C. The official-keyed material association is bronze. The other options deliberately move valid Harappan features to the wrong object or site.

Remedial MCQ 40

Which one of the following is the most UPSC-safe conclusion on Harappan decline?

- A. It was caused solely by an invasion.
- B. It proves every region experienced the same flood.
- C. It ended all cultural practices at once.
- D. It was a multi-causal, regionally uneven de-urbanisation with important Late Harappan continuities.

Answer: D. This conclusion integrates changed urban traits, varied causes and continuity. Single-event extinction narratives are stronger than the available evidence permits.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verification and answer protocol - [CORE MAINS]

- A question can be verified while its key remains unavailable or provisional. Never convert either condition into an official answer.
- Mains models follow **claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> verdict**.
- Six distinct original models replace overlapping rehearsals.

Verified Question 1 - 2019 Prelims GS-I Q7: Non-Harappan Site

Verified question; inferred answer/key - not officially verified. The local paper is available but the official key is not. Use the question as a site-classification drill: test each option's period, region and diagnostic material before selecting a non-Harappan site.

Why it matters: it rewards rejection of familiar-name bias; Harappan status must be established through context, not a famous archaeological label.

Verified Question 2 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q32: Ancient Water Harvesting

Verified question; inferred answer/key - not officially verified. The paper is locally available but no official key is held. The relevant preparation route is Harappan water management, especially Dholavira's reservoirs, without silently treating every Indus water structure as identical.

Verified Question 3 - 2025 Prelims GS-I Q72: Dancing Girl Material

Verified question; official Set-A key available locally. The Mohenjo-daro Dancing Girl is bronze. Use this as a material-culture distinction; it does not establish a complete social role or religious meaning.

Verified Question 4 - 2026 Prelims GS-I Q8: Household Artefacts and Inference

Verified question; provisional answer/key - not officially verified. The routed demand tests household artefacts, weights, construction and social inference. Do not record or infer an answer letter from the provisional local key; apply statement-level evidence limits.

Verified Question 5 - 2025 GS-I Q1: Salient Features of Harappan Architecture

Verified Mains question. No official model answer is implied. A defensible 150-word response uses planning, construction, water/drainage, public works, regional variation and functional-label caution.

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks: Civic Urbanism

Question (150 words): Explain why Harappan town planning demonstrates urban coordination without proving a known political system.

Model answer: Planned streets, standard brick practices, wells, bathing floors and covered drains make Harappan civic coordination unmistakable. Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath and Dholavira's water structures show investment in public or collective built form; Dholavira also warns against a universal two-part town plan. These features support organised maintenance, technical knowledge and shared construction norms. They do not reveal a king, council or empire, because the script is undeciphered and no unambiguous palace, royal tomb or king-list exists. Therefore architecture establishes coordinated urban practice, while the mechanism of political authority remains an archaeological inference rather than a settled fact.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks: Label Caution

Question (150 words): Why should terms such as 'granary', 'dockyard' and 'Pashupati' be used cautiously in Harappan history?

Model answer: These terms are modern functional or religious interpretations, not Harappan inscriptions. Buildings at Harappa/Mohenjo-daro called granaries, Lothal's basin called a dockyard, and the horned figure conventionally called Pashupati may be historically important, but their precise functions or identities are not settled. The undeciphered script prevents direct confirmation. A strong answer therefore begins with secure observation--a large structure, basin, seal image or associated context--then gives the conventional interpretation in quotation marks and names an alternative or limit. This keeps material evidence useful without converting archaeology into false textual certainty.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks: Urban-Rural System and Economy

Question (200 words): Analyse the relationship between Harappan urbanism, craft production and exchange networks.

Model answer: Harappan cities depended on an urban-rural system rather than isolated monumental centres. Agricultural surplus, pastoral resources and raw materials from varied ecozones supported settlements, while specialised craft produced beads, seals, metal objects, shell work and textiles. Chanhudaro and Lothal are useful craft associations; spindle whorls, scales and standardised weights show production and measurement. Internal movement of materials combined with long-distance links indicated by Meluhha, Dilmun and Magan connected the Indus world to wider exchange. Standardisation in weights, seals and bricks indicates shared norms and coordination. Yet it does not settle whether control came from one empire, city-level authorities or corporate elites. The strongest conclusion is a networked economy with significant integration and regional diversity, not a fully known state apparatus.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks: Script, Ritual and Social Inference

Question (200 words): Discuss how the undeciphered Harappan script shapes interpretations of religion and society.

Model answer: The undeciphered script makes the Harappan civilization an archaeological rather than textual reconstruction. Figurines, seals, fire installations, burials, houses and public structures can show material practices, repeated symbols and differentiated access. They cannot securely name deities, doctrines, caste groups, rulers or property rules. The horned figure on the so-called Pashupati seal, female figurines and possible cult objects should therefore be described first and interpreted second. Likewise, unequal house size may suggest differentiated access but does not prove a fixed class hierarchy. This limitation is not total ignorance: material evidence is strong for craft, planning, water management and exchange. It requires an answer to distinguish secure observation from plausible inference and leave ritual/social conclusions provisional.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks: Decline as Transformation

Question (250 words): Critically examine the decline of Harappan urbanism as a regional transformation rather than a sudden civilizational collapse.

Model answer: After c. 1900 BCE, several Mature Harappan urban traits declined, but the process was uneven and did not erase communities. River and environmental change, altered water conditions, shifts in exchange networks and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations. No one factor is securely sufficient for every region; invasion-only or flood-only stories overstate the evidence. The relevant outcome is de-urbanisation: large urban coordination weakened, settlement patterns changed and Late Harappan communities continued with regional material traditions and diversified agriculture. This framing explains both loss and continuity. It also respects chronology: a climatic or river proxy constrains a local context rather than automatically explaining the whole civilization. The best conclusion is multi-causal regional transformation, where urban forms changed but people, practices and material continuities did not simply disappear.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks: Standardisation and Authority

Question (250 words): Does Harappan standardisation prove political centralisation? Evaluate.

Model answer: Standardised bricks, weights, seals and aspects of town planning are powerful evidence of shared norms across a wide area. They support coordinated production, measurement, exchange and civic practice. Dholavira, Mohenjo-daro, Harappa and craft sites demonstrate integration alongside regional variation. However, standardisation does not identify the political mechanism. The absence of deciphered texts, king-lists, royal tombs, securely identified palaces and monumental temples prevents a confident monarchy model. Authority may have been centralised, organised through several city-states or mediated by corporate elites and shared institutions. A good answer therefore treats standardisation as evidence of integration and administrative capacity, not as proof of a named empire. The verdict is qualified: the Harappans achieved remarkable coordination, while the form of rule remains an unresolved archaeological question.